

Salary Negotiation Scripts for Every Situation

RenWork Digital Products

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Negotiation is not a guessing game; it is a structured conversation designed to align your value with the company's compensation structure. Most professionals fail not because they lack leverage,

but because they lack specific language to articulate that leverage without sounding aggressive or desperate. The following scripts are engineered to be precise, professional, and adaptable. Use them

as templates, but always inject your specific data points (market rates, performance metrics, or competing offers) to ground the request in facts.

Section 1: The Initial Offer Response

When you receive an offer, your immediate reaction should not be acceptance or rejection, but a pause. This pause signals that you are a serious candidate who evaluates all aspects of the role. Your goal here is to buy time and signal openness to discussion without committing to the initial number.

****The Standard Script:****

"Hi [Recruiter Name], thank you so much for sending over the offer details. I am very excited about

the opportunity to join [Company Name] and contribute to the [Specific Project/Team]. After reviewing the package, I would like to discuss the compensation structure further. Do you have fifteen minutes later today or tomorrow morning to chat about the numbers? I want to ensure we can

align on a figure that reflects the scope of the role and my experience."

****The "High Confidence" Variation:****

Use this when you know the initial offer is significantly below market rate.

"Thank you for the offer, [Recruiter Name]. I am genuinely impressed by the team and the

mission.

However, based on my recent market research and the specific value I bring to [Specific Responsibility], the current salary figure is lower than I anticipated. I am confident we can find a number that works for both of us. Are you available to discuss adjusting the base salary to better reflect the role's requirements?"

****Key Tactic:**** Never say "I hope you can do better." Instead, ask if they have flexibility. This shifts the burden of explanation to them, forcing them to reveal their budget ceiling or justify their floor.

Section 2: The Counter-Offer

Once you have opened the floor, you must make a specific counter-offer. Vague requests like "more money" are weak. You must anchor high but remain within a realistic range. If you believe your target is \$100,000 and the offer is \$85,000, do not counter at \$90,000. Counter at \$105,000 to allow room for negotiation.

****The Data-Driven Script:****

"Based on our conversation and my review of industry standards for [Job Title] roles in [Location/Industry], which typically range between \$[Low End] and \$[High End], I would like to propose a base salary of \$[Your Target + 5%]. Given my [Specific Achievement or Skill] that directly impacts [Company Goal], I believe this figure is competitively aligned with the value I will deliver from day one."

****The Competitor Anchor Script:****

Use this only if you have a written, active competing offer.

"I have received a competing offer from [Optional: Company Name] for \$[Competitor Salary]. While [Current Company] is my top choice due to [Reason], I would need the compensation package to be competitive with their offer to make this decision fair. Could we discuss adjusting the base salary to \$[Your Target] to match that level?"

****Key Tactic:**** After stating your number, stop talking. Silence is a powerful tool. Let the discomfort of the silence force the recruiter to respond, rather than you explaining or justifying your number immediately.

Section 3: Asking for a Raise

Negotiating a raise is different from negotiating a new hire salary because you are proving value already received. Do not ask for a raise based on tenure or personal financial needs. Ask based on performance, increased responsibility, or market correction.

****The Performance-Based Script:****

"Hi [Manager Name], I'd like to schedule a brief meeting to discuss my career progression and compensation. Since joining the team, I have [Specific Achievement 1] and [Specific Achievement 2], which resulted in [Quantifiable Result, e.g., 20% increase in sales/reduced costs by \$10k]. Additionally, I have taken on [New Responsibility] that goes beyond the original job description. Given these contributions and the current market rate for this level of impact, I would like to discuss adjusting my salary to \$[Target Amount]."

****The Market Correction Script:****

Use this if you have been underpaid for a long time and have done your homework.

"I've recently reviewed compensation benchmarks for [Job Title] in our sector. My current salary is [Percentage]% below the median market rate. I am fully committed to my role here and have consistently exceeded performance goals, as seen in my last two reviews. I would like to work with you to close this gap and bring my compensation in line with market standards, specifically to \$[Target Amount]."

****Key Tactic:**** Frame the raise as a retention tool for the company. You are not just asking for money; you are asking them to invest in keeping a high-performing asset.

Section 4: Negotiating Freelance Rates

For freelancers, the negotiation is about risk mitigation and value perception. Clients often try to negotiate rates down to avoid perceived risk. Your scripts must emphasize your reliability and the cost of hiring the wrong person.

****The Scope Expansion Script:****

"If we add [New Task] to the project, that expands the scope significantly. This requires an additional [Number] hours of work. I can accommodate this, but it will change the total project cost to \$[New Total]. Would you like to proceed with the expanded scope, or should we stick to the original deliverables to keep the budget at \$[Original Price]?"

****The Retainer Conversion Script:****

"Given the ongoing nature of our work together, I recommend moving from a per-project basis to a monthly retainer of \$[Retainer Amount]. This ensures I reserve [Number] hours per month specifically for your account, guaranteeing priority response times and consistent quality. It also simplifies the billing process for your finance team. Does that structure work for your budget?"

****Key Tactic:**** Never negotiate your hourly rate in isolation. Always tie it to the outcome. If they push back on price, offer to reduce scope, not price. Reducing scope protects your rate integrity; reducing price lowers your perceived value.

Section 5: Equity Asks

Equity negotiation is complex because it is illiquid. Do not accept "X shares" without understanding vesting, dilution, and strike price. Your script must demonstrate that you understand the mechanics and are asking for fair upside.

****The Standard Equity Ask:****

"I am very interested in the long-term trajectory of [Company]. To align my incentives with the company's success, I would like to discuss the stock option package. Based on the company's stage and standard practices for [Role Level], I would like to propose an equity grant of [Percentage]% of the company, vesting over four years with a one-year cliff. This structure ensures I am invested in the long-term growth while reflecting the current valuation."

****The Hybrid Compensation Script:****

"If the cash compensation remains at \$[Offered Salary], I would like to bridge the gap with equity. Specifically, I am looking for a package that includes [Percentage]% equity. This allows me to support my current financial obligations while participating in the upside potential of the company's future funding rounds or exit."

****Key Tactic:**** Always ask for the vesting schedule and strike price in writing. If they offer a high percentage of equity but with a high strike price (meaning the shares are expensive to buy), the actual value may be negligible. Negotiate for a lower strike price if the percentage is low.

Section 6: Benefits Negotiation

When salary bands are rigid, benefits become your primary lever. This includes remote work, additional PTO, learning stipends, or health insurance contributions.

****The Remote Work Script:****

"I understand the salary band for this role is fixed. However, I value flexibility highly. Could we discuss a hybrid arrangement where I work remotely [Number] days per week? This has allowed me to

[Benefit, e.g., maintain higher focus levels/reduce commute stress], which will directly translate to my productivity and output for the team. I am happy to guarantee availability during core hours of [Time Zone]."

****The Professional Development Script:****

"To ensure I can continue to bring cutting-edge solutions to the team, I would like to negotiate a professional development budget of \$[Amount] annually. This would allow me to attend [Specific Conference] and obtain [Specific Certification]. I believe this investment will yield a strong return on investment by enabling me to implement [Specific Strategy] within the first six months."

****Key Tactic:**** Quantify the benefit. Don't just ask for "more vacation." Ask for "three additional days of PTO to ensure I remain energized and productive throughout Q4." Tie every benefit ask back to how it helps the company achieve its goals.

Final Execution Notes

1. ****Preparation is Everything:**** Before any of these conversations, have your market data printed or on screen. If they ask "Why that number?", you must be able to cite sources like Glassdoor, Levels.fyi, or industry reports instantly.
2. ****Tone Check:**** Keep your tone collaborative, not adversarial. You are a partner in solving the problem